predecessor he was a polymathic non-specialist who wrote prodigiously on very many topics and themes.

The last chapter of Zaehner's *Hinduism* is called 'Yudhisthira's Return'. This innovatively—and to my mind, convincingly—compares the great leader of Indian nationalism to the eldest of the five Pandava brothers. Gandhi, writes Zaehner, was 'in history what King Yudhisthira was in myth, the conscience of Hinduism that hungers and thirsts after righteousness in defiance of the letter of the law of gods and men'.

Gandhi is hailed as the Father of the Nation; yet, as Zaehner reminds us, he 'did not see himself primarily as the architect of Indian independence from British rule but as the liberator of the Indian spirit from the fetters of greed and anger, hatred and despair'. Gandhi was 'the greatest reformer Hinduism has seen'. He transformed his faith, and very many of the faithful, by defining dharma, or righteousness, in terms of conscience and compassion, rather than by what was said in the sacred texts. Thus in his battle against Untouchability, Gandhi was moved, inspired and directed not by 'the *dharma* of the law-books and Brahmans, but the *dharma* that rests on *ahimsa*, truth, renunciation, passionlessness, and an equal love for all God's creatures …'

Both Yudhisthira and Gandhi, notes R.C. Zaehner, saw themselves as failures for being unable to prevent fratricidal warfare, between Pandavas and Kauravas in the one case, and between Hindus and Muslims in the other. Yet 'both were yet triumphant, for both had been true to themselves, to conscience, to Truth, to the *sanatana dharma* as they saw it in themselves, and therefore to God'.

V

Jordens and Zaehner both focus on how Gandhi understood, refined and revised Hindu thought and practice. They trace, with sympathy and insight, his career as a heterodox/unorthodox/reforming/radical interpreter of his own religious tradition. In this concluding section, I shall stress rather what